told INDIA TODAY that he "never used any red diary".

Gudha was among the six Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) MLAs elected in 2018, who later merged the party's entire legislature group with the Congress. In December 2021, Gehlot made him a minister of state—the only one from among those six and 15 or so Independent MLAs supporting the Congress government. It was seen as a reward after Gudha publicly claimed to have turned down an offer of Rs 20 crore to join Pilot's rebellion. Last year, however, he switched loyalties to the Pilot camp around the same time when there was a buzz about the latter being appointed CM if Gehlot went ahead with contesting the Congress presidential election. He has been critical of the Gehlot regime ever since.

Matters came to a head on July 21 when Gudha dubbed the crime rate against women in Rajasthan as worse than in violence-ravaged Manipur, puncturing the Congress's national strategy to corner the BJP on the issue. With Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa, the Congress general secretary in charge of Rajasthan, suspecting Gudha of acting in connivance with the BJP, Gehlot sacked him the same day. But Gudha fired a fresh salvo. He alleged that acting on Gehlot's instructions, the 'red diary' was one of the several documents that he along with another Congress leader had smuggled out of Rathore's Jaipur penthouse in July 2020, prior to an income-tax raid on the premises. Rathore was not holding any office then, and the raid at his house had followed an FIR registered against Union minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, whom Gehlot had accused of being behind Pilot's rebellion.

It is far from clear whether Gudha is indeed privy to inside information about money transactions, if any, during the rebellion or the attempts to save the Gehlot government, and if the 'red diary' contained any such details. His claims, though, are enough to set the political cauldron on the boil in assembly polls-bound Rajasthan.

The BJP has deputed Shekhawat and his cabinet colleague Smriti Irani to corner Gehlot, accusing him of sacking and heckling Gudha for raising the issue of crime against women and alleged horse-trading. Shekhawat, on July 24, alleged that some newspapers had reported in 2020 that a 'red diary' and some objectionable documents had been recovered in the raid but snatched from I-T officials. This would warrant an explanation: how, as a minister, did Shekhawat turn a blind eye to such reports back then, and why didn't the I-T officials file a police complaint?

However, there's no doubt that following Gudha's claim, Gehlot has a lot of damage control to do. The BJP will be determined to tap the issue in the election campaign and project Gehlot and his government as corrupt. At the same time, Gudha lacks credibility and it remains to be seen if his 'revelations', coming rather late in the day, cut ice with the electorate. ■

IT'S NOT CLEAR IF GUDHA IS INDEED PRIVY TO INFORMATION ABOUT HORSE-TRADING, BUT GEHLOT HAS A LOT OF DAMAGE CONTROL TO DO

By Dhaval Kulkarni

The BJP ranks have not taken kindly to the party roping in the Ajit Pawar faction of the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) into their alliance government in Maharashtra. For one, the party had to relinquish crucial portfolios like finance, cooperation, medical education and food and civil supplies to Ajit and his eight ministers. Then, BJP leader Devendra Fadnavis—who led the state from 2014-19—is playing second fiddle to Chief Minister Eknath Shinde. With Ajit also a deputy CM now, the role of Fadnavis has been circumscribed further. This is the first time that Maharashtra has had two deputy CMs. The claim by Ajit's men that he will soon replace Shinde at the helm has muddied the waters further (though this has been denied by Fadnavis).

The BJP has the lowest MLA-to-ministers ratio in the state. The party has only 10 ministers, including Fadnavis, despite having 106 MLAs (not counting the support of the legislators from smaller parties and independents), while Shinde's faction of the Shiv Sena has the same number of cabinet berths with 40 MLAs. Ajit, whose support base among the NCP's 53 MLAs is still unclear, has nine ministers. There are chances the cabinet expansion to fill the 14 vacancies may be delayed now, considering the number of claimants in Shinde's Sena. This means the wait will get even longer for the BJP's ministerial hopefuls. "There is disgruntlement among our MLAs," admits a senior BJP leader, "but the decision to take Ajit Pawar along has been prompted by the impending Lok Sabha election."

In 2019, the BJP and the then united Sena had secured 41 of Maharashtra's 48 Lok Sabha seats. A repeat is crucial if the BJP wants to secure a third term in Delhi, and the party hopes that the NCP turncoats, who are the local elite with a loyal vote base, will be able to transfer votes to their candidates. The BJP may also use the rebel NCP leaders to take on those from the Sharad Pawar-led faction, which is with the opposition Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA). For instance, Sunetra Pawar, the wife of Ajit Pawar, or Parth, his son, may be fielded against Sharad Pawar's daughter and sitting MP Supriya Sule from the Pawar family pocket borough of Baramati, says a senior